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Israel Film Festival Honorees, Jewish Federation's State Capital Visit and Beit T'Shuvah Ribbon Cutting

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The 35th annual Israel Film Festival (IFF) held its sponsor luncheon at the Four Seasons Hotel in Beverly Hills on April 29.

The afternoon gathering honored real estate investor, philanthropist and Holocaust survivor David Wiener with the IFF Humanitarian Award and actor Henry Winkler with the IFF Career Achievement Award.

Winkler, known for his role as Arthur "Fonzie" Fonzarelli on the legendary television series "Happy Days" and more recently for his Emmy-winning stint on HBO's "Barry," was touched by the acknowledgment. Accepting his award before a crowd of family members, community leaders and others, he declared, "I am a proud Jew!"

The 76-year-old performer also spoke about time spent recently in Israel working on a new television show, having only kind words to say about the Jewish State.

Those in attendance included IFF Founder and Director Meir Fenigstein, who said he was pleased to bring back the festival after a nearly two-year hiatus caused by the pandemic. Other participants were Consul General of Israel in Los Angeles Hillel Newman; comedian Elon Gold, who emceed the program; and actors Don Most and Anson Williams, who both starred with Winkler on "Happy Days."

Delivering the funny, Gold joked about those in the banquet room spreading both the love for Israel and the latest COVID-19 variant.

Singer Sharon Farber also turned out. During a rousing musical performance, Fenigstein, a musician in a previous life, accompanied Farber onstage while playing a percussive instrument.

Actor Mark Feuerstein and philanthropist-activist Daphna Ziman, respectively, presented Winkler and Wiener with their awards.

The luncheon was held a few days before the official kickoff to the Israel Film Festival, the largest showcase of Israeli entertainment in the United States, opens May 5 at the Saban Theatre in Beverly Hills and continues through May 26. During the three-week hybrid festival, Israeli feature films, documentaries and television series will show at various theaters across Los Angeles as well as online. For more information, visit israelfilmfestival.com.

On April 27, 19 members of the Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles' Real Estate and Construction (REC) Division and Real Estate Principals (RPO) traveled to Sacramento to advocate on critical issues facing the Jewish community.

The group focused their advocacy on the Nonprofit Security Grant Program, which provides critical assistance to nonprofit organizations at risk of hate-motivated violence to enhance physical security infrastructure as well as funding to support the rebuilding of camps and community centers destroyed by numerous California wildfires. These camps serve not only the Jewish community but many other diverse communities throughout the state.

According to the L.A. Federation, it was not lost on participants that this advocacy trip occurred on both the third anniversary of the tragic shooting at the Chabad of Poway in 2019 as well as on the eve of Yom Hashoah — these

historical markers underscoring the importance of the legislative asks. While in Sacramento, the Jewish Federation leaders met with key legislators and decision makers, including California Legislative Jewish Caucus Chair and State Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), and were hopeful that advocacy will translate into dollars for the California and Los Angeles Jewish communities.

On April 24, addiction treatment center Beit T'Shuvah (BTS) hosted a grand opening ceremony for its new thrift store location.

The BTS Thrift store, formally located in Culver City, now stands at the corner of La Cienega and Pico and serves as a resource for the community. The ceremony was attended by those in the Beit T'Shuvah community as well as Mayra Guevara, deputy for constituent services for the City of Los Angeles, who led in the ribbon cutting for the event.

The thrift store has always been a community favorite shopping experience with items ranging from furniture, art, clothing and more while supporting the critical work at Beit T'Shuvah. The mission of Beit T'Shuvah is to save the lives of those wrestling with addiction by providing integrated care in a community setting regardless of one's financial ability.

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